The Missing Piece

By Shel Silverstein

INTRODUCTION

A truly unique and multi-faceted artist, Shel Silverstein was a renowned poet, playwright, illustrator, screenwriter, and songwriter. Best known for his immensely popular children's books including The Giving Tree, Falling Up, and The Missing Piece, Silverstein has delighted millions of readers around the world, becoming one of the most popular and best-loved children's authors of all time.

In The Missing Piece, Silverstein concocts a marvelous tale with a powerful message: "Nno one should try to find all the answers, no one should hope to fill all the hopes in themselves, because a person without a search, loose ends, internal conflicts and external goals becomes too smooth to enjoy life." Never stop searching for The Missing Piece by Shel Silverstein.

It was missing a piece.

And it was not happy.

So it set off in search of its missing piece.

And as it rolled it sang this song-

"Oh I'm lookin' for my missin' piece

I'm lookin' for my missin' piece

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Hi-dee-ho, here I go,

Lookin' for my missin' piece."

Sometimes it baked in the sun

but then the cool rain would come down.

And sometimes it was frozen by the snow

but then the sun would come and warm it again.

And because it was missing a piece it could not very

fast so it would stop to talk to a worm

or smell a flower

and sometimes it would pass a beetle

and sometimes the beetle would pass it

and this was the best time of all.

And on it went, over oceans

"On I'm lookin' for my missin' piece

Over land and over seas

So grease my knees and fleece my bees

I'm lookin' for my missin' piece."

through swamps and jungles

up mountains

and down mountains

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Until one day, lo and behold!

"I've found my missin' piece," it sang,

"I've found my missin' piece

So grease my knees and fleece my bees

I've found my..."

"Wait a minute," said the piece.

"Before you go greasing your knees

and fleecing your bees..."

I am not your missing piece. I am nobody's piece.

I am my own piece.

And even if I was somebody's missing piece

I don't think I'd be yours!"

"Oh," it said sadly,

"I'm sorry to have bothered you."

And rolled on.

It found another piece

but this one was too small.

And this one was too big

this one too sharp

and this one too square.

One time it seemed to have found the perfect piece

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but it didn't hold it tightly enough

and lost it.

Another time it held too tightly

and broke.

So on and on it rolled,

having adventures

falling into holes

and bumping into stone walls.

And one day it came upon another piece that seemed to be just right.

"Hi," it said.

"Hi," said the piece.

"Are you anybody else's missing piece?"

"Not that I know of."

"Well, maybe you want to be your own piece?"

"I can be someone's and still be mine."

"Well, maybe you don't want to be mine."

"Maybe I do."

"Maybe we won't fit...."

"Well..."

"Hummm?"

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"Ummmm!"

It fit!

It fit perfectly!

At last! At last!

And away it rolled

and because it was now complete,

it rolled faster and faster.

Faster than it had ever rolled before!

So fast that it could not stop to talk to a worm

or smell a flower

too fast for a butterfly to land.

But it could sing its happy song,

at last it could sing "I've found my missing piece."

And it began to sing-

"I've frown my nizzin' geez

Uf vroun my mitzin' brees

So krease ny meas

An bleez ny drees

Uf frown..."

Oh my, now that it was complete it could not sing at all.

"Aha," it thought.

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"So that's how it is!"

So it stopped rolling...

and it set the piece down gently,

and slowly rolled away

and as it rolled it softly sang-

"Oh I'm lookin' for my missin' piece

I'm lookin' for my missin' piece

Hi-dee-ho, here I go,

Lookin' for my missin' piece."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shel Silverstein
ISBN: 978-0060256715
Publisher: HarperCollins Publishers, Inc
Date (Month/Year): May 1976

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier

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